

Case: The Confidential Briefing

Exam-style case analysis · Workshop material

Six weeks before the election, the Prime Minister was diagnosed with early-stage Parkinson's disease. Her doctor, Dr. Lane, did two things with the diagnosis. She entered it into the public hospital's patient records system, standard practice for any patient under monitoring. At the government's request, she also wrote a two-page confidential briefing for the Prime Minister's office. The briefing translated the raw diagnosis into what mattered politically: likely symptom progression over the next six, twelve, and twenty-four months, how tremor and fatigue might present in public settings, medication side effects, and a recommendation that disclosure be delayed until after the election. The diagnosis was a fact. The briefing was Dr. Lane's professional judgement about how the Prime Minister should be managed, and it existed only because she wrote it.

James Cole, the Prime Minister's chief of staff, received the briefing three ways. Dr. Lane handed him a printed copy at their first meeting. He read from it, and paraphrased its recommendations, in a phone call to a colleague two days later while walking between meetings. Ahead of a strategy session the following week, in a hurry, he asked Dr. Lane's office to email him a digital copy so he wouldn't have to carry the paper around.

Twelve days after that email, a journalist named Anna Price published a story reporting the Prime Minister's diagnosis. The story went beyond confirming she was ill: it reproduced, close to word for word, Dr. Lane's own projection of symptom progression and her recommendation to delay disclosure until after the election. That level of detail told the Prime Minister's office someone had read the actual briefing, or had it read to them. What they could not establish was which copy it came from.

The hospital's IT team checked the email. Dr. Lane's office had sent it once, to Cole's government address, and the logs showed no sign it had been forwarded. Cole could not say for certain what had happened to the printed copy after that first meeting. He thought it was still in his desk drawer, but the drawer wasn't locked, and other staff moved through the office routinely. Nobody could establish who might have overheard his phone call, or been told about it afterward, twelve days on.

Three weeks from the election, the Prime Minister's office knows the specific content of a document meant for a handful of people is now public. Whether it reached Anna Price on paper, over the phone, or on a screen remains unresolved, and there is little time left to find out.